

6, Technological Advancement Might Not Inevitably Facilitate Mutual Comprehension Among Global Peoples

At the end of last year (2024), during my writing process, I discovered a grim reality: the popularization of modern technology has fundamentally failed to make the peoples of distinct nations comprehend one another more profoundly. What proliferates most rapidly via the internet is not scientific comprehension, but conversely, assorted stereotypes and fallacies that are continuously reinforced within people's consciousness.

This discovery initially perplexed me. The earliest explanation I posited was that internet dissemination had increasingly fragmented information, and people no longer possessed the energy or inclination to engage in protracted reading and comprehensive logical contemplation; they merely unilaterally pursued information capable of stimulating their neurological excitement. However, I rapidly realized that this explanation ostensibly harbored flaws. The reason is that prior to the popularization of the internet, this disastrous phenomenon of "the greater the technological advancement, the deeper the estrangement" ostensibly had already emerged.

Although domestically it is phenomenally arduous for me to access a sufficient volume of documentary records authored by explorers, conquerors, and missionaries during the two centuries subsequent to the onset of the Age of Discovery (地理大发现), judging from the works bequeathed by missionaries who arrived in China during the late Ming (明) and early Qing (清) epochs—such as Matteo Ricci's (利玛竇) *De Christiana expeditione apud Sinas* (《利玛竇中国札记》), Juan de Palafox's (帕莱福) *History of the Tartar Conquerors of China* (《鞑靼征服中国史》), and Martino Martini's (卫匡国) *De Bello Tartarico Historia* (《鞑靼战纪》)—these initial cohorts of Westerners arriving in the non-Western world might not have been exceedingly clear regarding local historical realities, yet they possessed piercingly precise observations regarding the exact state of the local societies.

Mr. Matteo Ricci delivered a phenomenally precise commentary regarding the excursions of the Ming emperor. Observing the circumstances of the Chinese monarch traveling with heavy guard (出警入蹕), Ricci noted that this emperor appeared not to be touring the territory he himself ruled, but rather sprinting onto the soil of a mortal enemy's nation; because he perpetually harbored infinite hostility toward his own subjects, and identically dreaded that his subjects viewed him in the exact same manner. Mr. Palafox, having personally witnessed the Qing Dynasty's conquest of Southern China, identically pointed out with supreme precision that a paramount reason why the colossal behemoth of the Ming Dynasty was so effortlessly pulverized relative to the Manchus (满洲) was fundamentally that the Ming Dynasty possessed zero stratum of **feudal knights** (封建骑士阶层).

During the initial generations of contact, not exclusively regarding China, Europeans harbored a phenomenally precise intuitive perception regarding almost all non-European locales; this is something utterly unmatched today.

The absolute pinnacle of this formidable intuition known to me is the French thinker Alexis de Tocqueville (阿列克西·德·托克维尔). His *Democracy in America* (《论美国的民主》) constitutes an exceedingly astonishing masterpiece from my perspective; the entire book mentions China five times and delivers specific discourses (*excluding instances where China merely appears as incidental background*).

In the chapter "On the Democratic Government in America," Tocqueville states: "I shall not term nations akin to China as affluent nations, because they possess a colossal population count; although the aggregate wealth of China surpasses the aggregate wealth of Holland, individually speaking, the Chinese are poorer, while the Dutch are relatively wealthier." In the chapter "Why the Americans Are More Addicted to Practical Than to Theoretical Science," Tocqueville explicitly points out that China "extinguished the fire of its own civilization." Identically in this chapter, Tocqueville referenced Louis's viewpoint: if the number of Chinese were to decline in the foreseeable future, then at the very least, they are neither as progressive as I have stated, nor as formidable as European nations envisioned 60 years ago. In the chapter "Why So Many Ambitious Men and So Little Lofty Ambition Are to Be Found in the United States," Tocqueville points out that China's imperial examination system (科举制度) suppressed people's ambition to accomplish monumental enterprises. And in the chapter "Necessity of Examining the Condition of the States Before That of the Union at Large," the most astonishing description emerges: Tocqueville recounts that a traveler informed him, "**The Chinese have tranquility without happiness, industry without improvement, stability without force, and strict public condition without public morality.**" This society lacks any possibility for continued development whatsoever—naturally, the development they speak of here patently refers to positive progression.

This astounded me immensely; a French scholar researching a global masterpiece on America actually utilized a few brief sentences to deliver one of the most precise descriptions regarding the quintessential essence of China's **restoration-bureaucratic society** (复辟官僚社会) known to date. How phenomenally acute were the judgments of the Europeans of that era!

They perceived that the aggregate volume of social wealth possessed zero fundamental significance for the process of societal development; they perceived that China's stagnation and regression were intrinsically self-annihilation; they perceived that this colossal empire was fundamentally a giant with feet of clay; they could even perceive that China's agricultural society had already reached its absolute ceiling during the Daoguang (道光) era—without the intervention of Western technology, ecological catastrophe and demographic collapse were imminently inevitable.

Although we do not know the identity of that traveler, he straightforwardly pinpointed the core characteristic of a **restoration-bureaucratic society**: namely, "**ordered yet profoundly insecure**" (治而不安). This society ostensibly appears lethargic and devoid of mutation, yet every single individual exists within a state of extreme insecurity. From the emperor at the pinnacle down to the destitute commoners at the bottom, the matters they dread are merely diverse, yet there is fundamentally not a single person who does not feel terrified. This is precisely the consequence when power exercises absolute manipulation over the entirety of social life, yet is utterly incapable of being constrained, while concurrently being exceptionally unstable in its transmission.

When Tocqueville was authoring *Democracy in America*, the **Opium War** (鸦片战争) had fundamentally not yet commenced. The Qing Empire of that era possessed vast territories, and its population constituted thirty percent of the entire globe. This regime resolutely executed restrictive measures against external communication; it was virtually impossible for Westerners to penetrate China's interior (内地) to conduct activities. Even if they could enter, it was exclusively at designated locations, for limited durations, and accompanied by official personnel. The Qing Empire did not even desire foreign merchants to learn the Chinese language, forcing them to communicate with the Chinese exclusively through translators.

Regarding the velocity of information transmission, let alone transmitting at the speed of light, even steam-powered machinery was phenomenally limited in the Europe of that era. Yet the Western explorers and missionaries of that time were perpetually capable of transmitting such astonishingly precise information—information that leaves one profusely marveling even today, 200 years later. Exactly why is this the case?

The reason lies in the fact that the era was so primitive that, paradoxically, it became highly conducive to mutual comprehension among distinct nations. This seemingly contradictory relationship is concealed within the following reality: precisely due to the sheer scarcity of basic services and technological mechanisms, from the 1500s to the 19th century, when Westerners traveled to non-Western regions—particularly regions where the West had not established colonial rule—if they wished to conduct prolonged activities, they were structurally compelled to rely upon establishing stable social relations with the local populace. Consequently, they actually participated profoundly within the labyrinthine structural networks of the local society.

It was precisely this establishment of social relations and participation in social activities that enabled the Western pioneers of that era to render highly intuitive, undisturbed, and visceral judgments regarding the societal morphology of the region they inhabited. This is precisely where the fascination lies. If we examine exactly how missionaries like Matteo Ricci (利玛窦) attempted to preach in China, one conspicuously notices how drastically international interactions of that era diverged from those of today.

However, subsequent to the proliferation of Western science and technology, people today seeking accurate information about a specific nation fundamentally no longer rely on physically traveling there. Even for international travel, there is no longer any necessity to establish stable social relations with the locals. In an era where mobile applications can execute flawless translation, one can complete a tour of a moderately developed region merely through perfunctory hiring and asking for directions. In regions like Japan, where social public services and infrastructure are consummately perfected, a foreign tourist can execute an entire trip while practically uttering scarcely a single word.

Under modern conditions, people ostensibly possess vastly easier access to information originating from foreign countries; however, this information is neither intuitive, nor is it immune to interference, and it is overwhelmingly devoid of visceral experiential reality. The most fatal issue lies in the fact that it is becoming astronomically more difficult for an individual to comprehend the *de facto* social structure of another nation—namely, according to exactly what operational logic does this society function? If a tourist exclusively views homogenized skyscrapers, transportation infrastructure, and broadly renowned tourist attractions, this question fundamentally receives absolutely zero answers. Even after visiting the locale, it remains highly probable that they will still harbor profound misunderstandings. Under these bizarre mutations, science and technology have not erected a bridge for mutual comprehension among distinct nations; rather, they have manufactured "a deplorable, thick barrier" ("一层可悲的厚障壁" / *This description originates from Lu Xun's [鲁迅] short story "My Old Home" [《故乡》]*).

Consequently, we identically observe a globally renowned news topic that has emerged in recent years: Western developed nations have become exceedingly tense due to immigration. The reason is that people have discovered that the source countries of new immigrants in the new century frequently possess values that diverge colossally from those of the Western world. Judged from the

disparities in historical processes that we have delineated, this is an absolute inevitability. Even more disastrously, the new immigrants ostensibly do not integrate into Western society with much ease; they frequently and stubbornly maintain their original lifestyles and values.

Such novel mutations have undeniably provoked anxiety among Euro-American whites, while concurrently inciting a certain skepticism regarding confidence in Western values: *If the West is genuinely so incomparably advanced, then why can it not compel new immigrants to embrace its lifestyle and values?* I have noticed that numerous scholars have already pinpointed a reason: modern technology has rendered transportation and information unprecedentedly hyper-developed, and social media platforms enable new immigrants to construct communities exclusively with cohorts sharing identical cultural backgrounds. These mutations render the ties between new immigrants and their mother countries substantially tighter than in the past, thereby rendering them significantly less likely to effortlessly assimilate into the society of their host country.

Thus, the flip side of this explanation inevitably emerges: the development of science and technology, alongside the advancement of public services, dictates that even after migrating to a new locale, immigrants no longer possess the existential necessity to establish social relations in their new nation, unlike their predecessors who crossed the oceans during the modern era. Under modern conditions, immigrants residing in developed nations can live and work in relative isolation; even under such circumstances, their lives remain vastly superior to before they migrated. Consequently, they inevitably appear substantially more difficult to "assimilate" (同化).

I maintain that although this phenomenon of "modern technology exacerbating the estrangement among distinct communities" genuinely merits profound attention, and constitutes an exceptionally severe challenge for developed nations—particularly immigrant nations among them—one absolutely cannot deduce the conclusion that "Western values are decaying" strictly from this matter. Speaking without false modesty, the observations and reflections I have accumulated over the past two and a half years possess monumental significance for resolving this issue. It is precisely because the societal development of humanity is governed by universal laws across the entirety of historical periods, and because multitudinous nations separated by vast chasms of time and space have experienced highly analogous historical processes, that the existence of **universal values** (普世价值观) becomes exceptionally compelling.

Therefore, readers should naturally be capable of comprehending more profoundly exactly why I perpetually manifest two seemingly contradictory tendencies. On one hand, as a mathematics student, I emphasize the precision of conceptual definitions and strictly demarcate their distinctions vastly more intensely than scholars of a social science background. On the other hand, regarding certain conclusions, I earnestly note that they remain questionable.

Currently, colossal misunderstandings exist even among regions unhindered by an internet firewall; the difficulties I encountered when searching for specific materials within mainland China could only be exponentially greater. Furthermore, I have ultimately never physically traveled abroad. When hunting for information regarding foreign nations, I have already exerted my absolute utmost effort to reference the perspectives of their indigenous populace, deduce conclusions from relatively verifiable historical facts, and conduct multifaceted examinations and cross-references regarding existing conclusions. Yet, I definitively dare not assert that this alone is sufficient to categorically eliminate errors. Therefore, regarding areas in my research where doubts

conspicuously exist, I have opted to explicitly demarcate them. Readers must absolutely maintain a critical eye when reading my record!

6，技术进步对于各国人民相互了解未必是好事

在去年（2024 年）年底的时候，我在写作的时候发现了一个严峻的问题，那就是现代科技的普及并没有让各国人民之间变得更了解，借助互联网扩散最快的不是科学的认识，反倒是各种各样的刻板印象和谬误在人们的意识里被不断加强。这个发现在最开始时让我感到困惑，我最早给出的解释是互联网传播使得信息更加碎片化，人们不再有精力和意愿去进行长期的阅读和完整的逻辑思考，只是一味地去追求那些能够刺激自己神经兴奋的信息。然而很快我发现这个解释似乎有问题，原因是在互联网普及之前这种“技术越进步隔阂越大”的糟糕现象似乎就已经出现了。虽然我在国内很难阅读到足够多的地理大发现开始之后两个世纪里，探险家，征服者和传教士的文献记录。不过根据我对于明末清初时期来华的传教士们留下的作品，例如利玛窦的《利玛窦中国札记》，帕莱福的《鞑靼征服中国史》，和卫匡国的《鞑靼战纪》来看，这些西方来到非西方世界的第一批接触者未必对于当地的历史事实有多么清楚，但是对于当地的社会处于什么状态却有一针见血地准确观察。利玛窦先生对于明朝皇帝的出行给出了精确的评论，从中国君主出警入辟的情况来看，利玛窦说这位皇帝似乎不是在自己统治的疆土上出巡，而是跑到了死敌国家的土地上，因为他总是对自己的子民怀着无穷的敌意，也惧怕自己的子民以同样的方式看待他。帕莱福先生亲眼见证了清朝对于中国南方的征服，他同样极为精当地指出道，明朝相对于满洲这样一个庞然大物之所以被轻而易举地击败，一个重要的原因就是明朝根本没有封建骑士阶层。在接触开始的头几代人里，不只是中国，欧洲人对于几乎所有非欧洲地方都有一种极为精确的感知，这是今天都比不了的了。

我所知道的这种强大直觉的顶峰就是法国思想家阿利克西托克维尔（Alexis de Tocqueville），他的《论美国的民主》在我看来是一个极为惊人的著作，整本书中五次提到了中国并进行了某种论述（中国只作为事件背景出现不算）。在《美国的民主政府》这一章中，托克维尔说：“我不会将类似于中国这样的国家称为富裕的国家，因为它们具有巨大的人口数，尽管中国的总财富大于荷兰的总财富，但就个体而言，中国人较穷，荷兰人相对较富。”在《美国人在科学领域关注实践多于理论的原因》一章中，托克维尔明确指出中国“自己熄灭了文明之火”。也是在同一章托克维尔提到了路易斯的观点，即中国人的数量如果在可预见的未来下降的话，那么至少他们没有像我所说的那样进步，也不像 60 年前欧洲各国所设想的那样强大。在《为什么在美国有那么多雄心勃勃的人而少有怀揣远大理想的人》一章中，托克维尔指出中国的科举制度压制了人们做出一番大事业的野心。而在《探讨联邦政府之前有必要研究各州的过去》这一章中，最为惊人的描述出现了，托克维尔说一位旅行家告诉他“中国人拥有安宁而无幸福，拥有产业而无进步，拥有稳定而无冲劲，拥有严格制度而无公共道德”，这个社会不具备任何继续发展的可能，当然他们这里说的发展显然是指正向的。

这太令我吃惊了，一个法国学者研究美国的世界名著，居然用短短几句话给出了迄今为止对于中国复辟官僚社会本质最为精确的描述之一，当年的欧洲人判断是何其敏锐！他们看到了社会财富的总量对于社会发展进程不具备根本意义，看到了中国的停滞和倒退本质上是自我毁灭，看到了这个大帝国根本就是泥足巨人，甚至能够看到中国在道光年间农业社会已经发展到极限，如果没有西方技术的介入，生态灾难和人口崩溃就是马上要发生的事。我们虽然不知道那位旅行家的姓名，但是他却直截了当地指出了复辟官僚社会的特征，即“治而不安”。这个社会看起来死气沉沉，缺少变动，但是每个人都处于极端的不安全感当中，上到皇帝下到赤贫百姓，大家害怕的事情无非不同而已，却没有一个人不感到害怕。这就是权力完全左右了整个社会生活却又完全无法被限制，并且在传递上极为不稳定的结果。

在托克维尔撰写《论美国的民主》这本书的时候，鸦片战争还并没有开始，那个年代的清帝国疆域辽阔，人口占了全世界的三成。这个政权坚决地执行着对于对外交流的限制措施，西方人几乎不可能进入中国内地进行活动，就算能去也是在指定的地点，有限的时间由官方人员陪同。清帝国甚至不希望外国商人学习汉语，让他们只能通过翻译与中国人进行交流。从信息的传递速度来说，不要说能以光速传递，即使是蒸汽动力机械在当年的欧洲也非常有限。可是那个时候的西方探险家和传教士总是能够传递出这样准确的信息，即使放到 200 年后的今天也是让人赞叹不已的，为什么呢？

原因在于，那个时代太落后，以至于对于不同国家之间互相了解反倒成为一件好事。这个看似矛盾的关系隐藏在以下事实中，正是由于基础服务和技术手段匮乏，从 1500 年到 19 世纪，当西方人前往非西方地区的时候，特别是西方没有建立殖民统治的地区。他们要想长期活动就不得不依赖于与当地建立稳定的社会关系，进而实际上参与到了当地社会复杂的结构网络当中。正是社会关系的建立和社会活动的参与使得当年的西方先行者们能够非常直观的，不受干扰的，感性地对于所在地区的社会形态做出判断。这就是奇妙的地方，如果我们看看利玛窦这样的传教士是怎么试图在中国传教，就非常注意到当年的国际交往与今天的不同。

然而随着西方科学技术的扩散，现在人们想要准确获得那个国家的信息已经完全不依赖于一定要到当地去一趟。甚至即使是国外旅行，也不再需要与当地建立什么稳定的社会关系了，在手机 APP 完全可以实现翻译的年代，简简单单的雇佣和问路就可以到一个不是太落后的地区旅行一圈。而在日本这样社会公共服务和基础设施极端完善的地区，一个外国游客甚至可以几乎一言不发地完成旅行。在现代条件下，人们似乎更容易接触到来自外国的信息，但是这既不直观，也可能受到干扰，更缺少感性体验。而最为致命的问题在于，一个人越来越难以了解另一个国家实际上的社会结构，这个社会到底依据什么样的逻辑运动？如果游客仅仅去看同质化的高楼大厦，交通设施以及一些广为知名的景点，这个问题根本得不到任何解答，即使去了一趟当地依然产生误解是大概率的事。就在这样奇怪的变化下，科学技术不是架起了不同国家之间相互了解的桥梁，而是又创造出了“一层可悲的厚障壁”。（这个形容出自鲁迅的小说《故乡》）

于是我们还看到了近几年来出现的一个举世皆知的新闻话题，那就是西方发达国家因为移民变得十分紧张。原因在于人们发现新世纪的移民们的来源国往往在价值观上与西方世界差异极大，这从我们说明的历史进程差异来看是必然的。更糟糕的是，新移民们似乎没有那么容易融入西方社会当中，他们常常顽固地保持着原有的生活方式和价值观。这样的新变化毫无疑问引起了欧美白人的担忧，同时也使得人们对于西方价值观的信心产生了某种怀疑：如果西方果真无比先进，那么为什么不能使新移民们接纳它的生活方式和价值观呢？我注意到不少学者已经指出了一个原因，那就是现代技术使得交通和信息前所未有地发达，社交媒体平台使得新移民可以与同文化背景的人群建立社群。这些变化使得新移民与其母国的联系比过去更加紧密，因此也就不那么轻易地融入所在国社会。那么这个解释的另一面也就呼之欲出了：科学技术的发展，公共服务的进步使得移民到了新的地方也不会再像近代时期那些漂洋过海的前辈一样具有不得不在新国家建立社会关系的需求。在现代条件下，处在发达国家的移民完全可以比较孤立地生活和工作，即使如此也比移民之前过得要好，那么他们看起来就必然更不容易被“同化”。我认为这样一种“现代技术加剧不同社群之间隔阂”的现象虽然非常值得重视，对于发达国家特别是发达国家中的移民国家来说更是很严峻的挑战，不过从这件事情上肯定是得不到“西方价值观衰败”这个结论。不谦虚地说，我在过去两年半里的见闻和思考对于解决这个问题是有很意义的，正是因为人类的社会发展从整个历史时期看受普遍规律支配，许许多多国家在时空中相隔遥远的地方经历过相似的历史进程，普世价值观的存在才变得特别有说服力。

因此读者应该也能更加理解我为什么总是展现出两种看似矛盾的倾向，一方面我作为数学专业的学生比社科出身的学者要更加强调概念定义的准确性并尽可能明确其区别，另一方面我对于一些结论又会诚恳地写它尚且存疑。现在即使是没有互联网防火墙的地区之间都已经存在很大的误解，我在中国大陆查找一些资料的时候遇到的困难只能更大，况且我毕竟没有实实在在地出过国。在寻找有关外国资料的时候，我已经竭尽全力去参考本国人的观点，从比较确定的历史事实中获得结论，对于已有的结论进行多方考察和对比，但是我肯定不敢说这样就已经能够排除掉错误。因此我对于研究中明显存在疑虑的地方就选择标明出来。读者阅读我的记录时也一定要带着批判的眼光啊！